

Denmark where, for example, the Swedish characters are seen to be more politically correct than the Danish. Danish and Swedish audiences may feel that *The Bridge* confirms longstanding views and reaffirms the separate cultural identities. Conversely, some may feel that this is unfair cultural stereotyping.

- Cultural capital, for example an understanding of the conventions of film noir or of other Nordic Noir dramas will enhance the viewing experience of the audience.
- Gender, for example women may be empowered by the construction of positive female representations in *The Bridge*.
- Audiences who are interested in crime dramas that offer a different cultural experience are likely to have a positive response to the programme.

Theoretical Approaches: Reception Theory – Stuart Hall

Consider Hall's assertion that there are three hypothetical positions from which messages and meanings may be decoded, in relation to *The Bridge*:

- An audience may understand and accept the producers intended meaning, to construct a programme that appeals to audiences by including some typical conventions of the crime drama whilst offering something different and more challenging through the character of Saga and the Scandinavian setting. These viewers will be entertained by the programme, its complex narrative, and the intertextual references to film noir.
- Feminist audiences are likely to feel empowered by the inclusion of strong, powerful women in the storyline, by the representation of a lesbian relationship and the narrative addressing gender issues.
- Some audiences may assume a negotiated position, they may enjoy the typical codes and conventions of a crime drama, the enigmas, and the involvement with the investigative narrative, but feel more uncomfortable with the specific focus of the narrative. Swedish and Danish audiences may engage with the drama but feel that the cultural depictions are stereotypical.
- An oppositional audience reading may struggle to find Saga a sympathetic character. Audiences may view her behaviour traits with concern or find it difficult to connect to her emotionally as her responses are so different to expectations and she lacks humour. A more conservative audience may respond negatively to the Swedish liberal attitudes to sex, gender, and political correctness.

PART 5: STARTING POINTS – Media Contexts

• Social and Cultural contexts. Consider:

- The fact that the programme reflects the changing attitudes towards gender and specifically introduces a discourse into the narrative of this series around gender, identity, and LGBTQ issues.
- The representation of gender in the programme, including the construction of Saga's character, is influenced by changing social and cultural attitudes regarding the role of women in society.
- The binary opposition of the Swedish and Danish cultures highlights how issues may be treated differently in different cultures.
- Responses to *The Bridge* may reflect the social and cultural circumstances of the audience.

• Historical context

- *The Bridge* demonstrates that genre conventions are historically relative and dynamic.
- The representations constructed in the programme are affected by the historical context, they subvert and challenge typical representations that have been accepted over time and in doing so reflect the society of the time.
- Different audience interpretations of *The Bridge* may reflect historical circumstances.

• Economic contexts

- *The Bridge* demonstrates the economic advantages of international co-productions.
- The creation of the Nordic Noir brand meant that programmes could be successfully marketed globally.
- Establishing the codes and conventions of this style of programme builds a loyal fanbase and reduces the economic risk.

Acknowledgements

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